climatologists had worked out in 2009. The science has evolved, but the predicted risks of burning fossil fuels remain dire.

"… the conservation of natural resources is the fundamental problem. Unless we solve that problem it will avail us little to solve all others."

Theodore Roosevelt

Saving trees

Forests are a valuable natural asset that Earth cannot afford to lose. Their diminished numbers pose a significant threat for the climate; trees are "carbon sinks," meaning they take in carbon dioxide and use it to fuel growth. This then prevents carbon from contributing to global warming. Trees are a renewable resource, and people, businesses, and nations often plant them to offset fossil fuel use, but not in sufficient numbers. According to Friends of the Earth, the annual loss of forests worldwide directly causes 15 percent of global greenhouse gas emissions.

Rain forests, estimated to contain 50 percent of the world's species, are particularly vulnerable to deforestation. Up to 20 percent of the Amazon rainforest alone has been lost in the past 50 years. As "Our Common Future" suggested, part of the problem is that developing countries can earn money from large corporations if they clear rainforests for mining, logging, and cash crops. In Indonesia, for example, intensive deforestation took place to make way for palm oil plantations. Greenpeace reports that the amount of Indonesian rainforest logged, burned, or degraded in the last 50 years is equivalent in area to twice the size of Germany. The UN and other bodies now offer countries technical advice and financial incentives to manage their forests in a more sustainable way.